

Back from the margins

There was a time when Dane's name was spoken in the same breath as Lanning, Heather Knight, and Harmanpreet Kaur, young captains galvanising their setups and teaching their sides new ways to raise the ceiling of ambition. A freak ankle injury pushed her to the sidelines and triggered a vicious cycle of weight gain and mental health struggles. Failing a two-kilometre time trial by 18 seconds and subsequently being dumped from the national side did not go down well with the all-rounder, who publicly took on CSA thereafter.

Still active in the franchise circuit, recurring injuries made a return to her peak nearly impossible. While the fear of being left behind was one issue, self-doubt proved the bigger monster for the former captain. The casualty ended up being her valuable leg-spin.

"It's frustrating. Leg-spin is my life. With everything that transpired, a lot of confidence went with that. I was quite hard on myself. So the smallest bad ball would mean I convinced myself that I couldn't bowl at all. It snowballed from there. The more bad balls I bowled, the more it felt like being under a magnifying glass. So I put it on the back burner a bit and focused on my batting to regain some confidence," Dane told *Sportstar*. The first South African woman to take 100 ODI wickets, incidentally during the 2017 World Cup qualifier, Dane eyed a route back into the side as a specialist batter.

After the 2024 World Cup, newly appointed head coach Mandla Mashimbyi adopted a less hardline approach to South Africa's controversial fitness policy.

"Sometimes, the media and people can really make things look bigger than they really are. As long as a player can look like a cricketer, move like one, and think like one, I am happy," he said when asked about Dane's return from retirement in August 2025. She wore the South African crest for the first time in four years against Ireland last year and performed commendably in the

middle order, scoring 62 runs in two games at just under 230, at times also thriving as a finisher.

The bitterness surrounding the spate of retirements had also torn the Proteas dressing room apart. Over the years, a new core has developed and younger leaders have emerged, but the scars from words exchanged in the past have not entirely vanished. Mashimbyi has been determined to leave the past behind and focus instead on players capable of delivering results.

A calf injury, followed by illness, sidelined Dane for South Africa's white-ball tour of New Zealand and the home series against India, threatening her World Cup availability as well. Her inclusion in the squad also likely signals the end of the road for someone like Anneke Bosch, another specialist batter whose meagre returns appear to have exhausted the patience of the management.

"She's always been part of the plan for this World Cup," Du Preez revealed. "She's been working at the



Spearheading charge: The in-form Laura Wolvaardt (right) will lead South Africa for the second tournament in a row. GETTY IMAGES

High Performance Centre (in Pretoria). Dane is a strategic decision within our batting lineup and brings stability and experience. She's in good shape. Her leadership experience can also be valuable to this side," he added.

The South African line-up flying to England represents perhaps the best blend of the old and new guard from the nation's golden generation in women's cricket. The strategic inclusions also underline a clear intent from the ecosystem to do everything possible to finish on the podium and make this side one of the tournament's most compelling teams to follow.

Will England witness a long-awaited coronation, or will it be another chapter in the same hell loop for a nation still waiting for victory? A testing summer of cricket will decide.